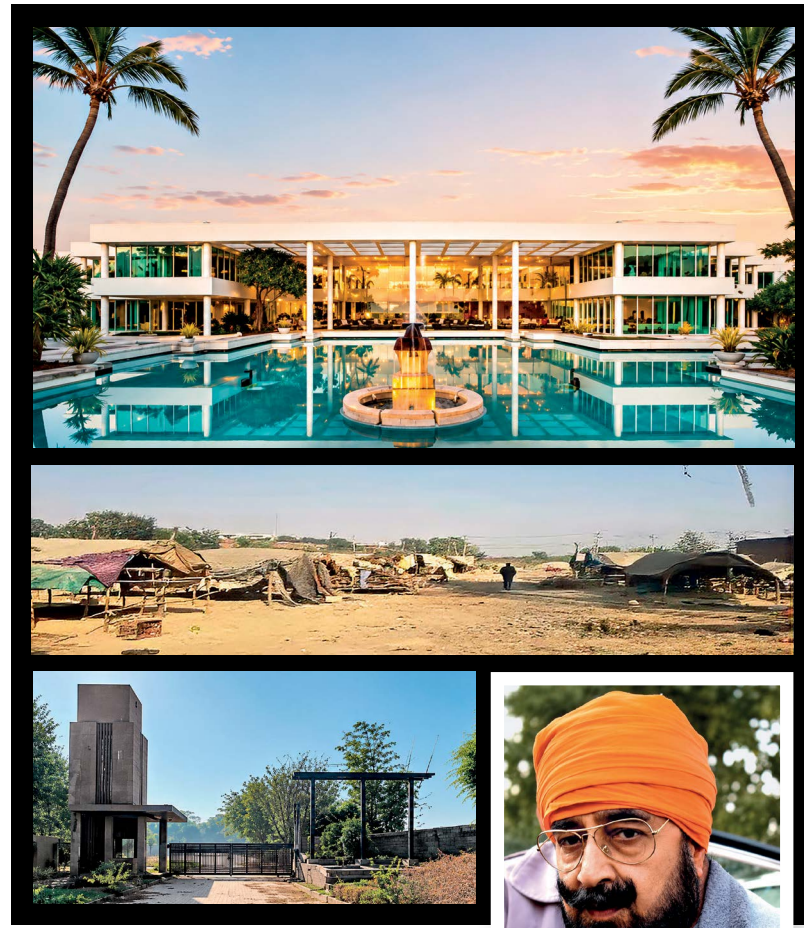
been duped by PACL's sprawling agent network and other trappings of legitimacy. Like the fancy documents—powers of attorney, agreements et al—and the halo lent by top-tier sporting tinsel: sponsorship of the World Kabaddi Cup, the IPL, Lee's boyish smile.

They didn't see that beyond the glitz was a plain ponzi scheme. Money from new investors was partly paying off older ones—just enough to sustain the illusion of a functioning enterprise. The rest of it was bankrolling elite properties—the Sheraton Grand Mirage Resort in Queensland, Australia, a villa in Auckland, New Zealand, et al. Front entities got a lengthening list of properties in India. Some were sold off, the proceeds going to directors and shareholders, all in the family. The grey ops setup was neat: like shell companies in Kolkata receiving transfers disguised as land development expenses; cash being withdrawn, transiting via hawala.

In 2014, that 18-year-old empire crumbled when the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) registered an FIR following a Supreme Court (SC) directive. The ED stepped in to pursue the money trail. In 2018 came its first big international strike: attaching the Sheraton's sale proceeds. Soon, it filed a prosecution complaint before a special court under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002—the first ray of hope for despairing investors.



TAKING IT ALL BACK From right clockwise, Nirmal Singh Bhangoo; property attached in Gahaur and Ludhiana in Punjab; the Sheraton Grand Mirage Resort in Queensland, Australia

MONEYBACK POLICY

FY26 saw an unprecedented spurt of action by the ED. The Justice R.M. Lodha committee, set up by the SC to oversee the liquidation of PACL assets and its restitution, had found widespread illegal dissipation of its properties. The agency acted swiftly, issuing seven Provisional Attachment Orders and attaching assets worth Rs 26,324.17 crore. Before that financial year, assets attached in the PACL case were valued at just Rs 706.4 crore.

The new seizures include holdings in the names of M/s PACL Ltd, associate entities, as well as Bhangoo's family. The ED deployed its full arsenal of legal tools to net the accused who fled abroad. The UAE is set to move soon on its request to extradite Prateek Kumar, backed by Interpol's Red Corner, Blue Corner and Silver Notices. The last, enabling global tracing of fugitive assets, targets Rs 2,285.79 crore transferred to him. Bhangoo's wife Prem Kaur, daughters Barinder and Sukhwinder, and the latter's husband Gurpartap Singh have got non-bailable warrants.

The last two saw proceedings under the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act. Barinder was declared a Proclaimed Offender; her husband, Harsatinder Pal Singh Hayer, was arrested. Letters Rogatory were issued in Madagascar against Pearls Tourism Malagasy. In Australia, the ED attached a residential property belonging to Barinder in 2025, and sought further evidence regarding two entities, Miigroup Holdings and Miiresorts Group 1. Acting on a request for help from asset recovery network ARINAP, New Zealand alerted the ED of an Auckland property once held in the names of Prem Kaur and Kulwaran Singh, and sold in 2015. On June 1, the ED attached 14 immovable properties belonging to Gian Sagar Educational & Charitable Trust, with a market value of Rs 1,595.85 crore, at Ramnagar, Punjab. In all, Rs 28,626 crore is back now.

The most heartening development came on March 30, when the special court ordered the restitution of 455 immovable properties, with an approximate market value of Rs 15,582 crore, to the Lodha committee—it will now oversee their liquidation and the distribution of proceeds to defrauded investors. Recoveries under the PMLA have, until now, been repatriated to the government. For the first time, this order turns victims into beneficiaries. ■